LEGACY, LEARNING AND THE LABOUR OF VISION

Long before 'international campuses' became a policy priority, one visionary was quietly building an Indian university network across continents. As India looks to export its educational excellence, Dr. Ramdas M Pai's journey offers a masterclass in soft power, persistence, and pioneering spirit.



Dr. Ramdas Madhav Pai
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On certain mornings in Manipal, when the air hangs heavy with the scent of rain-soaked earth and the plateau is still shaking off its dreams, the town feels like a place where ideas arrive early—long before the world realises it needs them. It is fitting, then, that one of India's most quietly disruptive ideas was born here, in a place that does not shout its contributions but lets them ripple outward across continents.

The Prophet Ahead of Policy

In 2020, when the National Education Policy finally declared that Indian universities should take their campuses overseas, policymakers treated it as a momentous pivot—an overdue step toward reclaiming India's position as a Vishwa Guru. But in Manipal, the announcement felt less like a revelation and more like déjà vu. The blueprint had already been drafted, tested, refined, and institutionalised nearly thirty years earlier by a soft-spoken man who rarely spoke of himself: Dr. Tonse Ramdas Madhav Pai.

Dr. Pai, who turned ninety this September, did not wait for policy mandates or diplomatic agreements. By the time India was cautiously prising open its economy in the early 1990s, he had already begun asking a question that seemed almost out of place in that era of controlled ambition: Why can't Indian education go global?

While most institutions were occupied with the grind of domestic anxieties—affiliations, inspections, infrastructure deadlines—Dr.Pai was poring over maps of Dubai, Malaysia, Nepal and the Caribbean. He was imagining agreements where none yet existed, and charting pathways no Indian educationist had dared to explore. His vision was not tentative. It was direct, almost startling in its clarity: "In a world of shrinking distances and countries with open borders, Manipal will be recognised as one of the largest global varsities in India."

He said this years before the word "internationalisation" seeped into Indian academia, long before Indian institutions began courting foreign students, and decades before the government saw global campuses as a matter of national strategy.

It was a prophecy disguised as a simple statement. And it became the compass by which he guided Manipal Academy of Higher Education (MAHE), transforming what was once a single medical college founded in 1953 by his father, Dr. T.M.A. Pai, into India's first multinational multi-disciplinary